became more of a politician and less of a soldier – he trusted the wrong advisors and tried to play politics when he should have stayed above that stuff and concentrated on governance. If he wanted to be a leader, he needed to not act like the others. Frankly, soldiers don't know much about politics. That's a sad fact. Why they behave like politicians, I just can't say. Perhaps Imran bhai has a point when he says that our generals behave like politicians and our politicians behave like generals.

Leaders need to have a good eye. It is this eye which helps them pick a good team. It is this team that remains united as it marches towards a uniform objective. A bad eye leads to bad team selection and a bad team puts even the best leaders out of a job. In fact, a bad team destroys everything: it first turns on itself and then the system it is trying to play within.

But good leaders must have a sense of humour too. I remember visiting FATA (Federally Administered Tribal Areas, now a part of the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province), the tribal badlands in the northwest, to inaugurate a cricket academy the army had helped me start up. General Raheel Sharif was the chief guest. I was just hanging around with him in the VIP stand and during a particularly dull phase, he asked me when the match was starting. I saw an opportunity to have some fun. I told him that the match was not starting anytime soon. General Sharif was a little startled. We were in Waziristan, after all. Not a place you can be hanging around all week. He gave me a semi-annoyed look.

So I eased in my plan and told him the match would only start once he'd face my bowling. He laughed me off. But I didn't budge. So, Raheel Sharif being Raheel Sharif said sure, why the hell not.

As we were walking up to the pitch, he told me that he was going to smash me for a four. I'm not sure whether that was a plan or an order or both. I decided it was in the nation's and my interest for the army chief to hit me for a boundary. So I bowled an unreasonably easy ball to him and he – showing no mercy – smashed me over mid-wicket for what was a remarkably powerful shot from a 56-year-old man. We both had a good laugh about it. Clips of the encounter went viral.

There's another instance of a fun moment, this time with another great soldier, General Musharraf. It was the year 2000 and we were in Lahore. Three days earlier, I had got married before a big match versus England. I did remarkably well with a five-for and a half-century. General sahib was in attendance, of course.

After the match, he came up to me and congratulated me for a job well done. Now, knowing him, he couldn't just congratulate me and decided to slip in a comment. He said something along the lines of, 'Afridi, your performance has improved after marriage.' At which point, I couldn't hold back and said, 'Well, sir, in that case, I think I'm gonna go for a second marriage to doubly improve my performance.' We had a grand laugh and then he said that a second marriage wouldn't be a bad idea if I could score a century and get 10 wickets. Thank God, the media was not around, or the feminists would have chewed us both up for that banter.

But seriously, Musharraf sahib had the chance to fix it all during his tenure. Too bad the politicians got to him before he could change the system.